PROCESS & TIMELINES

Objective of the Grand Innovation Challenge

The Simhastha 2028 is a huge logistical feat and requires expertise from different disciplines including technology, urban design, urban planning, behavioural science, and supply-chain management to augment institutional capabilities and ensure a safe clean and comfortable pilgrim experience.

The Grand Innovation Challenge shall encourage solutions that move beyond isolated demonstrations toward deployable, interoperable and measurable systems capable of functioning at the scale and complexity of Simhastha 2028.

Cross-Cutting Innovation Requirements

Although the four problem statements are presented separately, Mobility, Crowd Management, Sanitation and Logistics are highly interconnected.

For example:

Increased pilgrim arrivals → increased crowd density → increased waste generation → increased sanitation demand → increased service-vehicle movement → increased traffic → potential congestion → delayed replenishment/cleaning → further crowd and sanitation pressure.

Therefore, solutions that can operate across multiple domains or integrate with a common Simhastha Command, Control and Data Ecosystem may provide significant operational value.

Solutions should demonstrate:

- Practicality: Designed to address local conditions and requirements.
- Scalability: Ability to handle very high and rapidly changing demand
- Real-time capability: Ability to process and act upon live operational information
- Predictive capability: Ability to anticipate demand, congestion, crowd build-up or resource requirements
- Interoperability: Ability to interact and integrate with other solutions and exiting government systems and processes.
- Privacy and security: Privacy first approach
- Reliability: Operation under challenging field conditions
- Low-connectivity resilience: Offline/edge capabilities wherever required
- Cost effectiveness: Suitable for temporary as well as permanent deployment
- Ease of deployment: Minimal dependence on complex permanent infrastructure
- Human-in-the-loop: Technology should support, rather than unnecessarily replace, field personnel and decision-makers
- Measurability: Clearly defined KPIs and outcomes
- Sustainability: Low energy consumption, resource efficiency and reduced environmental impact

- Replicability: Potential for deployment in other large religious gatherings, festivals, pilgrimages and mass-gathering events

Timelines

The Grand Innovation Challenge will run for a duration of 12 months during which winning applications are expected to curate solutions to meet local requirements. The phases of the Challenge are explained below:

- **Challenge Launch | October 2026:** The Grand Innovation Challenge will officially launch on the 28th of October at the Urban Conclave in Indore. With the launch, the Challenge will be open to applications.
- **Submission of proposals | till December 28th, 2026:** Enterprises and academic institutions from across the world are encouraged to apply. Interested applicants will have eight weeks from the launch to submit proposals on one or more themes. To apply, click on the Apply Now button on the landing page of the Grand Innovation Challenge. Please submit a detailed proposal in the google form. The Challenge team will reach out to the main point of contact for any additional information or clarification.
- **Announcement of winning entries | February 2027:** Proposals will be evaluated by an expert panel of judges and winning entries will be announced in February of 2027. The panel will include members of the administration, and subject matter experts. Individual conversations will be organized with each selected applicant to determine validity, eligibility, merit and commitment for the duration of the Challenge.
- **Solution development and pilot deployment | February to September 2027:** Winning entries will have eight months to curate solutions for the Simhasth and deploy pilots in a pre-defined precinct area. The pilot precinct will be mutually decided based on discussions with the Challenge team.
- **Deployment at scale and institutional integration: October 2027 onwards:** Applications with potential for real impact and scalability will be asked to work with the administration to deploy solutions at scale.